MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 1: Revisiting Shakespeare

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Revisiting Shakespeare means asking how changing critical methods reveal meanings that earlier celebrations of universal genius may overlook.

Start with a picture

A torch lights one part of a dark room. Another torch reveals something different. Critical approaches work like these lights: they make questions visible, but none automatically illuminates everything.

1. Why revisit a celebrated author?

Shakespeare’s place in education, theatres, publishing, and national identity was historically produced. Literary skill matters, but popularity and cultural authority also depend on institutions, teaching, translation, and performance.

The Elizabethan theatre was itself a commercial and social institution. Its audiences, censorship, patronage, and representations of rule are part of its cultural significance.

2. Psychoanalysis: motives beneath awareness

Ernest Jones interprets Hamlet through Freud’s Oedipus complex. In this reading, unconscious desires and repressed conflicts help explain the difficulty of revenge. The uncle becomes troubling because his actions resemble a desire the hero cannot openly acknowledge.

This is a critical hypothesis, not a diagnosis established for a real person or a fact Shakespeare explicitly announces. Ask what passages support it and which parts of the play it may leave unexplained. Jones’s developed book Hamlet and Oedipus appeared in 1949; the course’s 1899 label should not be used as its publication date.

3. Postcolonial criticism: the construction of outsiders

Ania Loomba examines racial, religious, national, and cultural differences in Shakespeare. The Prince of Morocco in The Merchant of Venice supplies an example of exclusion through racialised description. Other figures and terms reveal how supposed civilisation can define itself against an outsider.

Distinguish a character's prejudice, the play's dramatic handling of it, and a critic's interpretation. They are not automatically identical.

4. Marxist criticism: material relationships

Ask who owns resources, who performs labour, what exchange means, and how institutions sustain inequality. This approach can also examine how texts are sold, taught, and performed. It is not restricted to finding one wealthy villain in a plot.

5. Feminist criticism: gender and authority

Valerie Traub's work directs attention to sexuality, patriarchal households, and the construction of gender. The Taming of the Shrew makes women's obedience and marriage especially visible as critical problems.

A feminist reading asks how language and action distribute agency, whose experience becomes central, and how an ending naturalises or unsettles hierarchy. It is more precise than counting strong and weak women.

6. New Historicism: self-fashioning

Stephen Greenblatt's **self-fashioning** describes the shaping of identity through available social models and authority. A person does not invent a self outside all cultural conditions.

Read literary and non-literary documents in relation. In an Othello discussion, ask how expectations of masculine honour and sexual reputation make identity vulnerable. Context is part of meaning, not a decorative paragraph added before analysis.

7. Cultural materialism: institutions now

Alan Sinfield questions how modern Shakespearean institutions help construct cultural authority. A company's staging, selection, funding, and claims to bring culture to "the people" deserve examination. Distributing prestigious works does not by itself settle who controls the prestige or whose voices remain excluded.

Quick check

1. Is a psychoanalytic reading a proven medical fact? **No.**
2. Does postcolonial criticism only mean changing a costume? **No; it examines historical power and representation.**
3. Can present-day theatre institutions be objects of criticism? **Yes; cultural authority continues to be produced.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain cultural authority as historically produced.
2. Introduce two or three distinct methods.
3. Attach each to a named critic and specific example.

4. Consider a modern performance institution.
5. Evaluate what evidence and limits each approach involves.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not conflate all critical approaches or treat an attributed interpretation as an established fact about Shakespeare’s personal beliefs.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How do modern approaches change what it means to study Shakespeare?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Modern approaches challenge the assumption that studying Shakespeare consists only in appreciating timeless character and beautiful language. They do not necessarily deny artistic achievement. Instead, they investigate the relationships through which characters, language, and cultural authority become meaningful. The result is a broader field of evidence and a different set of analytical questions.

Psychoanalysis locates conflict partly in motives inaccessible to conscious explanation. Jones’s Hamlet reading illustrates how an interpretation can reconstruct an inward struggle beneath a character’s stated reasons. Postcolonial and feminist approaches shift emphasis towards the production of difference. Loomba’s outsider analysis and Traub’s gender questions show that descriptions of identity may also distribute power and legitimacy.

New Historicism connects literary meanings with contemporary practices of identity and authority. Greenblatt’s self-fashioning makes the self neither entirely free nor merely passive. Cultural materialism extends the inquiry into the institutions that transmit Shakespeare in the present. Sinfield’s criticism of theatrical authority asks how a seemingly generous project of cultural distribution can still preserve hierarchy.

The methods must be tested through close reading. An unsupported declaration that a play is patriarchal or colonial is weaker than an account of who speaks, how a scene positions an outsider, or what a production changes. A comparative answer can also identify limits: one lens may explain unconscious motivation while another better explains the social vocabulary through which that motivation is expressed. Revisiting Shakespeare keeps interpretation open to such differences.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. What is the cultural significance of the theatre in Elizabethan England?
2. Detail some of the features of psychoanalytic criticism with reference to Ernest Jones.
3. List examples of marginalised representations of ‘Outsiders’ in Shakespeare as discussed by Ania Loomba.
4. What are some of the specific concerns of Marxist literary criticism?
5. According to Valerie Traub, how are women portrayed in The Taming of the Shrew?
6. What is Self-Fashioning? How does New Historicism discuss the concept with relation to Othello?
7. Detail Alan Sinfield’s critique of the Royal Shakespeare Company.